

settings for the desktop and the netbook workspaces. These settings override the KDE defaults.

Arch Linux does not provide such packages, and uses the default templates. The standard KDE defaults are provided in *apps/plasma/layout-templates*. The base directory is */usr/share* in Arch Linux, and */usr/share/kde4* in Kubuntu.

The netbook workspace consists of a panel, a default page and a 'defaultSal'. The panel usage and concept is pretty clear. 'Sal' is the search and launch activity shown on the main desktop. It replaces the menu, and eliminates the need for it in the panel. The 'page' is a recently introduced 'newspaper' containment which has widgets like news and weather embedded in it, with fixed size and layout, unlike in a desktop containment. A similar concept in Meego is the status tab, which integrates the desktop with some social networking sites like Twitter, Facebook and Last.fm. You can learn more about the KDE netbook interface from <http://akademy2009.kde.org/conference/papers/SouzaAD-Akademy2009.pdf>.

The contents of each containment are defined by a Javascript file. These are much easier to manage than the numerous XML files typical of a GUI. Once the initial set-up is done, configuration files are created in *.kde4/config*, and any customisation of them is easily done using KDE's graphical tools.

I expect that we will continue to see more action on the netbook (and mobile) interfaces. The introduction of GNOME Shell may impact Meego and Ubuntu Unity, as they are based on GNOME. It would also be interesting to see how QT applications are integrated into Meego, as that is the direction expected of Nokia.

It is fun to understand how to customise the user interfaces for a netbook; however, the significance of customisation probably extends far beyond netbooks. In my view, there are strong reasons for manufacturers to create custom looks for their notebooks and PCs as well. From my recent experience as a consumer, given the choices we face in our daily life (http://www.ted.com/talks/lang/eng/sheena_joyengar_on_the_art_of_choosing.html), isn't it strange that we don't have more choice in the marketplace regarding desktop interfaces? I like to believe that KDE 4 and GNOME 3 will eventually make it a commercial reality. Just one vendor has to take the lead. 

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